



Wild strawberry was said to "comfort fainting spirits."

Habitat & Cultivation Wild strawberry is native to Europe and temperate regions of Asia. The leaves and fruit are gathered in early summer.

Parts Used Leaves, fruit.

Constituents The leaves contain flavonoids, tannins, and a volatile oil. The fruit contains fruit acids and a volatile oil with methyl salicylate and borneol.

History & Folklore Wild strawberry appears to have been little used medicinally until the Middle Ages. Writing in 1652, Nicholas Culpeper listed its benefits: "the berries are excellent good to cool the liver, the blood, and the spleen, or a hot cholerick stomach ... the leaves and roots thereof [are] also good to fasten loose teeth and to heal spongy foul gums."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Wild strawberry leaves are mildly astringent and diuretic. The plant is little used medicinally today, but it can be taken to treat diarrhea and dysentery. The leaves were used as a gargle for sore throats, and in a lotion for minor burns and grazes. In Europe, the fruit is considered to have cooling and diuretic properties, and has been prescribed as part of a diet in cases of tuberculosis, gout, arthritis, and rheumatism.

Fraxinus excelsior (Oleaceae)

Ash

Description Deciduous tree growing to 130 ft (40 m). Has pale grey bark, black conical leaf buds, and bright green leaves with 7–13 oval leaflets.

Habitat & Cultivation Common in Europe, ash thrives in lowland and moorland. The leaves are gathered in summer, but the bark is gathered in spring.

Parts Used Leaves, bark, seeds.

Constituents Ash leaves contain flavonoids, tannins, mucilage, triterpenes, and iridoids.

History & Folklore The ash was the "world-tree" of Norse mythology, its roots spreading to the domain of the gods, and its branches extending to the remotest corners of the universe. In Norse myth, the first man was carved from a piece of ash wood. In parts of Europe, ash bark was used as a cost-free substitute for quinine in the home treatment of malaria. Such use probably continued in rural areas into the 20th century.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Ash bark is tonic and astringent. Little used in herbal medicine today, it is occasionally taken for fever. The leaves are also astringent, and they have a laxative and diuretic effect. They have been used as a mild substitute for senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75).

Related Species The bark of the American white ash (*F. americana*) has been used as a bitter tonic and astringent. Several ash species exude a nutritious sap, called "manna," which is used as a laxative for children. In particular, the manna ash (*F. ornus*), which has antioxidant activity, has been cultivated in southern Europe for its high yield of manna sap.

Fucus vesiculosus (Fucaceae)

Bladderwrack,

Kelp

Description Brownish-green alga growing to 3 ft (1 m) in length. Has flat, usually forked, fronds containing air bladders.

Habitat & Cultivation Bladderwrack is native to the North Atlantic shores and western Mediterranean, and is harvested all year.

Part Used Whole plant.

Constituents Bladderwrack contains polyphenols, polysaccharides, and minerals, especially iodine (up to 0.1%). The polysaccharides are immunostimulant. The iodine may stimulate the thyroid gland.

History & Folklore Bladderwrack has been employed as a fuel, as a winter feed for cattle, and as a source of iodine and potash.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Due to its iodine content, bladderwrack is taken as an antigoiter remedy. The plant appears to raise the metabolic rate by increasing hormone production by the thyroid gland, though this increase may be limited to poorly functioning thyroids. Bladderwrack is reputedly helpful in rheumatic conditions.

Research In one clinical trial (Italy 1976), patients taking bladderwrack lost much more weight than the control group. In more recent German research, the polyphenols and polysaccharides appeared to have antiviral and anti-HIV activity.

Cautions Do not take if pregnant or breastfeeding. If suffering from a thyroid illness or taking insulin, take only under professional advice.

Fumaria officinalis (Fumariaceae)

Fumitory

Description Climbing annual growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has compound leaves and maroon-tipped pink tubular flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and North Africa, fumitory also grows in Asia, North America, and Australia.

Parts Used Flowering aerial parts.

Constituents Fumitory contains isoquinoline alkaloids and flavonoids.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A notably bitter-tasting herb, fumitory has a stimulant and cleansing action on the liver and gallbladder, and is principally used to treat chronic itchy skin problems such as eczema. It is also diuretic and mildly laxative.

Related Species Fumitory is related to corydalis (*Corydalis yanhusuo*, p. 86), and *F. parviflora* from central Asia. The latter, like fumitory, is used as a detoxifying, laxative, and diuretic herb.

Caution Fumitory is toxic in excessive doses. Use only with professional advice.



Fumitory may be applied externally as a treatment for eczema.